



# Your Child's First Plan

## Understanding Early Intervention and the IFSP — Birth Through Age 3

*Knowledge is power. Partnership is progress. Together — the IEP gets APPROVED.*

### Your Child's Journey Starts Here

If your child is under age 3 and has a developmental delay or disability, they may qualify for Early Intervention services under Part C of the Individuals with Disabilities Education Act (IDEA). These services are delivered through an Individualized Family Service Plan — the IFSP. It is not an IEP yet, but it is the foundation of everything that comes next.

**The most important thing to know: Early Intervention works. The earlier services begin, the greater the impact on your child's development. Do not wait.**

### What Is Part C of IDEA?

Part C of IDEA is the section of federal law that governs early intervention for infants and toddlers with disabilities from birth through age 2. Part C requires states to provide early intervention services to eligible children at no cost to families.

■ *IDEA Part C, 20 U.S.C. § 1431 et seq.*

### Who Qualifies?

A child from birth through age 2 qualifies if they:

- Have a diagnosed physical or mental condition that has a high probability of resulting in developmental delay (e.g., Down syndrome, cerebral palsy, hearing loss)
- Have a developmental delay in one or more areas: cognitive development, physical development, communication, social-emotional development, or adaptive/self-help skills
- Are at risk of developmental delay (eligibility varies by state)

### How to Access Early Intervention

**Step 1 — Refer your child:** Anyone can refer a child for Early Intervention — parents, doctors, childcare providers, or neighbors. Call your state's Early Intervention program directly. You do not need a doctor's referral.

**Step 2 — Evaluation:** The state must evaluate your child within 45 days of referral. The evaluation is free. You must give written consent before evaluation begins.

**Step 3 — Eligibility determination:** A team reviews the evaluation results and determines whether your child is eligible for services.



**Step 4 — IFSP meeting:** If eligible, an IFSP meeting is held within 45 days of referral. You are a required participant.

**Step 5 — Services begin:** Services begin as soon as possible after the IFSP is agreed upon.

## What Is the IFSP?

The Individualized Family Service Plan is a written document developed by a team that includes you — the caregiver. The IFSP is different from an IEP in one key way: it is family-centered, not just child-centered. It recognizes that supporting the family is how you support the child.

### What the IFSP Must Include

| IFSP Component                       | What It Means                                                                                         |
|--------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Your child's present levels</b>   | Current development in all five areas: cognitive, physical, communication, social-emotional, adaptive |
| <b>Family information</b>            | Your family's resources, priorities, and concerns related to your child's development                 |
| <b>Measurable outcomes</b>           | Specific results expected for your child and family — with timelines                                  |
| <b>Early intervention services</b>   | What services, how often, where (natural environment), and who provides them                          |
| <b>Natural environment statement</b> | Why services are or are not provided in the natural environment (your home, daycare, community)       |
| <b>Service coordinator</b>           | One person responsible for coordinating all services and helping you navigate the system              |
| <b>Transition plan</b>               | A plan for transition to Part B services (preschool IEP) beginning at age 2 years 6 months            |

## Head Start and Early Intervention

Head Start is a federally funded preschool program for children from low-income families, ages birth through 5. Early Head Start serves children from birth through age 3. Head Start and Early Intervention can work together — your child can receive both at the same time.

### Key things to know:

- Head Start programs are required to reserve at least 10% of enrollment for children with disabilities
- If your child is enrolled in Head Start and has an IFSP, Early Intervention services can be delivered in the Head Start setting
- Head Start staff can help connect families to Early Intervention and other community resources
- Head Start and Early Intervention must coordinate transition planning when your child turns 3
- Head Start programs have a Disabilities Services Coordinator — ask to meet with them

## Your Rights Under Part C

- [ ] Right to a free evaluation — at no cost to you
- [ ] Right to give or withhold consent — for evaluation AND for services



- ☐ Right to participate in developing the IFSP
- ☐ Right to receive services in the natural environment
- ☐ Right to an assigned service coordinator
- ☐ Right to request a review of the IFSP at any time
- ☐ Right to dispute resolution if you disagree
- ☐ Right to receive services in your primary language
- ☐ Right to receive a copy of the Procedural Safeguards notice

---

## Preparing for Your IFSP Meeting

My child's strengths and personality (what I want the team to know):

---

---

My biggest concerns about my child's development:

---

---

Services I want to ask about:

---

---

Questions I have for the team:

---

---

---

## Coming Up Next: The Age 3 Transition

When your child turns 3, Part C services end and Part B begins — meaning a preschool IEP replaces the IFSP. This transition must be planned before your child's third birthday. See our companion guide: "From IFSP to IEP — The Age 3 Transition Guide."